OTT ▼

THE FEAR IS REAL

Smita Singh taps into our inner demons for her Amazon Prime horror series *Khauf*



When Smita Singh moved to Delhi in 1998, little did she know that her experience would drive her to create *Khauf*. "I lived in a working women's hostel, and the danger and isolation that women coming from small towns faced every single day, the fear of being followed, being watched, the feeling that your space is never truly yours, was our constant companion," says Singh. In fact, it is the exact alley that Singh would have to survive to reach her hostel in the Qutub Institutional Area, that makes a spooky appearance in *Khauf*.

The series follows Madhu (Monika Panwar), leaving behind her traumatic past to seek a new life in Delhi, where she moves into a haunted hostel. Elsewhere, a creepy healer (Rajat Kapoor) is trying to prolong his life by consuming the souls of young women. More than the computer-generated ghouls, the daily experiences of working urban women with hostile men are close to the bone.

Singh, an FTII screenwriting graduate, broke into the industry as a staff writer on Netflix's *Sacred Games*. An acclaimed thriller (*Raat Akeli Hai*) later, she is now the creator and showrunner of her own series. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh



A still from *Khauf*

CINEMA ▼

A Suitable Boy

SPARSH SHRIVASTAVA's dance moves got him to the city of dreams, but it's his thespian skills which have ensured he stays on and shines

Accidental actor. That's the phrase Sparsh Shrivastava uses to describe his 16-year run as an entertainer. The Agra boy was 11 when he won the dance reality show, *Chak Dhoom Dhoom*. Acting wasn't on the horizon, he says, but his connection with the camera was undeniable and, by 2017, he knew that Mumbai was to be his new home. Last year, the 27-year-old actor's breakthrough moment came with *Laapataa Ladies*, where his convincing turn as a naive groom stuck with somebody else's wife tickled as well as won hearts. In March, he scored another hit as a young wannabe with Bollywood on his mind in the Amazon Prime sitcom *Dupahiya*. And last month, Sparsh made a case for being a multi-hyphenate artist after releasing his first single, *Ji Huzoor*. "I want to set an example for the audience and say that if you want to do something in life, you don't have to rely on excuses," he says. "Work hard and you will get there."

It has taken him a while to find his way in the industry. By his own account, he has given some 400 auditions and had his share of rejections. "I never saw it as a struggle," he says. "I enjoy giving auditions. It's a way to practise my craft." It's how he'd bag his first prominent role in *Jamtara*. Aamir Khan would see the Netflix show and call to congratulate him. And that video call would land him another audition, a life-changing one for the Khan-produced *Laapataa Ladies*.

A self-taught dancer, actor and now singer, Sparsh says if TV was his school and OTT his graduation, then currently he is in his post-grad phase. Not a flash in the pan but a *"lambi race ka ghoda"* [one for the long haul] is what he seeks to be. ■

—Suhani Singh



The 27-year-old scored a hit as a young wannabe with Bollywood on his mind in ***Dupahiya***

PARAG JALGAONKAR